



Data Protection and Handling Policy

EFFECTIVE 01 JULY 2026

VERSION 1.0

WARNING!

Information contained in this document is intended
for flight simulation purposes only.

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Purpose of Document

This document establishes the official Data Protection and Handling Policy for VATSIM Sub-Sahara Africa (VATSSA). It sets out the conduct and expectations that new and existing members of VATSSA shall follow when participating in any divisional activities, systems or services within VATSSA. VATSSA staff reserve the right to take action against any user found to be breaching this policy. This policy has been developed to achieve the following objectives:

- To establish clear standards for the handling, protection, and appropriate use of personal data within VATSSA systems and activities.
- To define the rights, responsibilities, and expectations of users in relation to VATSSA's processing of personal data.
- To ensure compliance with applicable data protection legislation, including EU GDPR, and alignment with VATSIM's Data Protection and Handling Policy.
- To ensure that personal data is processed fairly, securely, and transparently in all VATSSA operations.

VATSSA is committed to delivering a professional, supportive, and safe environment for all, regardless of their home division. As such, this policy applies to all individuals whose personal data is processed by VATSSA in connection with divisional activities, operations, or engagement through VATSSA platforms and systems.

1. Control Pages

1.1. Document Identification

Type	Policy
Revision	05/2026
Issue Date	
Effective Date	
Prepared By	Wian Saptouw - VATSSA1 & Josh Martin - VATSSA3
Approved By	Wian Saptouw – VATSSA1 (Division Director)
Next Review Due	1st January 2027
Identification	VATSSA_POL_DPHP_06-2026.pdf

1.2. Revision Records

Version	Date	Description	Author
1.0	06/2026	Initial Policy Drafted	

2. General Provisions

2.1. Applicability

This policy applies to all members and visitors of the VATSIM Sub-Sahara Africa division whose personal data is processed by VATSSA, regardless of their home region. It also applies to any individuals whose personal data is processed in connection with interaction with VATSSA systems, services, or activities. Members are responsible for familiarising themselves with the contents of this policy, as well as any relevant VATSIM policies. VATSSA's Data Protection Officer holds full discretion to waive or amend aspects of this policy as necessary for VATSSA's benefit.

The content of this document reflects the essential modifications and regulations concerning EU GDPR and VATSIM's Data Protection and Handling Policy.

2.2. Non-Compliance

Failure to comply with this policy, particularly in relation to the improper handling, access or processing of personal data, may result in immediate referral to the VATSIM Membership Department and, where applicable, the VATSIM Board of Governors.

2.3. Changes

This policy is subject to periodic review and amendment. Amendments may be made by the VATSIM Sub-Sahara Africa Data Protection Officer as required to address its clarity and effectiveness. Members will be expected to comply with the most current published version of this policy, which will be published at vatssa.com.

VATSSA does not knowingly process or collect data from children under the age of 13.

If it is believed that VATSSA has inadvertently collected or processed personal data belonging or relating to a child under the age of 13, the Data Protection Officer should be contacted without delay so that appropriate action can be taken, including the review and, where necessary, the erasure of data.

3. Definitions

Term	Definition
Staff Member	Any member of the VATSIM Sub-Sahara Africa staff team.
Member	An account holder / user is considered a member of the VATSIM community.
Personal Data	Any information relating to an identified or identifiable natural person, e.g., name, email address, age.
Data Protection Officer	The person responsible for ensuring the management, organisation and processing of data within VATSSA is EU GDPR compliant.
Consent	A freely given, specific, informed and unambiguous indication of a data subject's wishes by which they, by a statement or by a clear affirmative action, signifies agreement to the processing of personal data relating to themselves.
Legitimate Interest	The processing is needed for your legitimate interest or the interests of a third party.

4. Data Protection Principles

VATSSA is committed to complying with the seven principles of data protection as set out in Article 5 of the EU General Data Protection Regulation. All staff and members who process personal data on behalf of the organisation are expected to understand and adhere to these principles.

4.1 Lawfulness, fairness and transparency

4.1.1 Lawfulness

VATSSA shall process personal data lawfully. Personal data is only processed under the basis of legitimate interests in accordance with Article 6 of the EU GDPR. Data subjects must be provided with clear information regarding the collection, use and retention of their personal data.

4.1.2 Fairness

VATSSA shall ensure that personal data is processed fairly and in a reasonable manner that individuals would expect, in accordance with Article 5(1)(a) of the EU GDPR. Personal data must not be used for purposes that are incompatible with the reason for which it was originally collected, nor shall it be used in a manner that could cause unjustified harm or disadvantage to an individual.

4.1.3 Transparency

VATSSA shall ensure that individuals are provided with clear and accessible documentation regarding the processing of their personal data, in accordance with Articles 12–14 of the EU GDPR. Information relating to the use, collection, processing, retention, sharing and protection shall be made available through VATSSA's Privacy Policy and VATSSA's Data Protection & Handling Policy.

4.2 Purpose Limitation

Personal data must only be collected for specified, explicit and legitimate operational purposes related to VATSSA activities, in accordance with Article 5(1)(b) of the EU GDPR. Data may not be further processed in a manner that is incompatible with those purposes unless otherwise permitted under applicable data protection legislation or VATSSA policy.

All processing purposes must be clearly defined and documented within VATSSA systems, and individuals must be informed of such purposes through VATSSA's Privacy Policy and VATSSA's Data Protection & Handling Policy.

4.3 Data Minimisation

Personal data shall be adequate, relevant, and limited to what is necessary in relation to the purposes for which it is processed, in accordance with Article 5(1)(c) of the EU GDPR.

VATSSA shall only collect and process the minimum amount of personal data required for specified, legitimate and explicit operation of VATSSA services.

Personal data must not be collected on a “just in case” basis or processed for purposes that are not clearly defined, necessary, and proportionate to the operation of VATSSA services.

4.4 Accuracy

Personal data shall be accurate and, where necessary, kept up to date. Every reasonable step must be taken to ensure that personal data which is inaccurate, having regard to the purposes for which it is processed, is erased or rectified without delay, in accordance with Article 5(1)(d) of the EU GDPR.

This principle applies proportionally depending on the nature and purpose of the data processed. In some cases, personal data may remain static over time, while in other cases it may require regular updates to remain accurate.

VATSSA shall take appropriate measures to ensure that personal data remains accurate and up to date, where necessary, including allowing members the right to rectification.

4.5 Storage Limitation

Personal data shall be kept in a form which permits identification of data subjects for no longer than is necessary for the purposes for which the personal data are processed; personal data may be stored for longer periods insofar as the personal data will be processed solely for archiving purposes in the public interest, scientific or historical research purposes or statistical purposes in accordance with Article 89(1), subject to implementation of appropriate technical and organisational measures required by this regulation in order to safeguard the rights and freedoms of the data subject in accordance with EU GDPR Article 5(1)(e).

This principle shall be applied by VATSSA through defined retention periods ensuring that personal data is not stored for longer than is necessary for operational purposes related to VATSSA activities.

4.6 Integrity and confidentiality

Personal data shall be processed in a manner that ensures appropriate security of the personal data, including protection against unauthorised or unlawful processing and against accidental loss, destruction or damage, using appropriate technical or organisational measures in accordance with EU GDPR Article 5(1)(f).

All VATSSA staff shall comply with applicable information security and data protection procedures and policies. Staff shall take appropriate steps to ensure that personal data is kept secure at all times against unauthorised or unlawful processing, loss or disclosure, and in particular will ensure that personal data held within VATSSA's infrastructure is protected by the use of secure passwords.

4.7 Accountability

VATSSA shall be responsible for, and be able to demonstrate compliance with the data protection principles set out in Article 5 of the EU GDPR, in accordance with Article 5(2) of the EU GDPR.

VATSSA shall maintain appropriate records, policies, and organisational measures to ensure compliance and understanding of data protection principles.

VATSSA shall regularly review its data protection and handling policy and its privacy policy to ensure ongoing compliance with EU GDPR.

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5. Lawful Basis of Processing

VATSSA processes certain personal data under the lawful basis of legitimate interests in accordance with Article 6(1)(f) of the EU GDPR. These legitimate interests relate to the operation, administration and security of a voluntary online aviation simulation network.

5.1 Legitimate Interests

- VATSSA is a voluntary community promoting flight simulations and virtual air traffic control, and all users seeking to join have an obvious interest in such activities.
- The data collected is the minimum required to allow for the smooth and optimal running of the network, including the protection of the network and community, solely for the enjoyment of its users.
- That the data is necessary to allow for VATSSA to operate as a like-minded hobby organisation, providing a community-minded environment for simulated pilots and controllers to interact in a singular virtual sky.
- That the data is necessary to allow for VATSSA staff to properly manage the network, both in day to day operations, and in circumstances where a user may act in a manner that breaches both network and local policy.
- That as all users have a shared interest in these aims that the collection of such data should be reasonably expected by all users.

5.2 Balancing Test

VATSSA has carried out a balancing assessment in relation to EU GDPR Article 6(1)(f).

VATSSA has assessed the impact of processing against the rights of data subjects. Given the voluntary nature of participation, the limited scope of data collected and the operational necessity of the processing, VATSSA considers that its legitimate interests are not overridden by the rights of data subjects.

Appropriate safeguards are in place to protect personal data, including role-based permissions, two-factor authentication, logging and secure passwords.

6. Data Subject Rights

The EU GDPR provides data subjects specific rights relating to the collection, processing, storage, and disclosure of their personal data. VATSSA shall take reasonable steps to ensure that these rights are respected and that requests relating to them are handled in accordance with EU GDPR and VATSIM policy.

6.1 Right to be Informed

Unlike many other data subject rights, which generally require a request from the data subject, the right to be informed is an obligation placed upon VATSSA under Articles 13 and 14 of the EU GDPR.

VATSSA shall provide data subjects with information about the processing of their personal data at the time the data is collected or, where personal data has not been obtained directly from the data subject, within the timeframes specified by the EU GDPR.

This obligation is fulfilled through the provision of a privacy policy relevant to the purposes for which VATSSA processes personal data. The privacy policy shall be concise, transparent, intelligible, easily accessible and written in clear and plain language.

A privacy policy shall include but is not limited to:

- The contact details of VATSSA's Data Protection Officer
- A clear description of the purposes of the processing and the legal basis for the processing, including the applicable condition under Article 6(1) EU GDPR.
- Details of any recipients or categories of recipients with whom personal data may be shared.
- The period for which personal data will be retained, or the criteria used to determine that period.
- Details of the rights available to data subjects under the EU GDPR.
- Where processing is based on consent, information on how consent may be withdrawn.
- Details of the data subject's right to lodge a complaint with the relevant supervisory authority.

VATSSA shall make its privacy policy readily available to data subjects through vatssa.com.

6.2 Right of Access

6.2.1 Responsibility

Requests for personal data under the right of access are the responsibility of the division director and their team. Such requests are required to be complied with within one month of the request being received. If circumstances prevent this from occurring, an extension of a further two months may be instituted by the data protection officer, provided that the member making the request is informed of this fact before the expiration of the original one-month deadline.

6.2.2 Procedure for making a request

Right of access requests must be in writing. Members are requested to make their written request via email to the data protection officer.

If VATSSA staff receive anything that might reasonably be construed to be a request for access, they have a responsibility to pass this to the data protection officer without delay.

6.2.3 Provision for verifying identity

Where the person managing the access procedure does not know the individual personally, there should be provision for checking their identity before handing over any information.

6.2.4 Fee Provisions

VATSSA will not charge any fee for providing data for requests under the right of access.

6.2.5 Exemptions

To ensure there is no retaliation or harassment against VATSSA staff, and to protect the privacy of staff members, names of staff may be redacted.

6.3 Right to Rectification

6.3.1 Responsibility

Requests for personal data under the right to rectification are the responsibility of the division director and their team. Such requests are required to be complied with within one month of the request being received. If circumstances prevent this from occurring, an extension of a further two months may be instituted by the data protection officer, provided that the member making the request is informed of this fact before the expiration of the original one-month deadline.

6.3.2 Procedure for making a request

Right to rectification requests must be in writing. Members are requested to make their written request via email to the data protection officer.

If VATSSA staff receive anything that might reasonably be construed to be a request for the right to rectification, they have a responsibility to pass this to the data protection officer without delay.

6.3.3 Provision for verifying identity

Where the person managing the access procedure does not know the individual personally, there should be provision for checking their identity before handing over any information.

6.3.4 Fee Provisions

VATSSA will not charge any fee for providing data for requests under the right to rectification.

6.3.5 Exemptions

To ensure there is no retaliation or harassment against VATSSA staff, and to protect the privacy of staff members, names of staff may be redacted.

6.4 Right to Erasure

6.4.1 Responsibility

Requests for personal data under the right to erasure are the responsibility of the division director and their team. Such requests are required to be complied with within one month of the request being received. If circumstances prevent this from occurring, an extension of a further two months may be instituted by the data protection officer, provided that the member making the request is informed of this fact before the expiration of the original one-month deadline.

6.4.2 Procedure for making a request

Right to erasure requests must be in writing. Members are requested to make their written request via email to the data protection officer.

If VATSSA staff receive anything that might reasonably be construed to be a request for the right to erasure, they have a responsibility to pass this to the data protection officer without delay.

6.4.3 Provision for verifying identity

Where the person managing the access procedure does not know the individual personally, there should be provision for checking their identity before handing over any information.

6.4.4 Fee Provisions

VATSSA will not charge any fee for providing data for requests under the Right to erasure.

6.4.5 Exemptions

To ensure there is no retaliation or harassment against VATSSA staff, and to protect the privacy of staff members, names of staff may be redacted.

6.5 Right to Restrict Processing

6.5.1 Responsibility

Requests for personal data under the right to restrict processing are the responsibility of the division director and their team. Such requests are required to be complied with within one month of the request being received. If circumstances prevent this from occurring, an extension of a further two months may be instituted by the data protection officer, provided that the member making the request is informed of this fact before the expiration of the original one-month deadline.

6.5.2 Procedure for making a request

Right to restrict processing requests must be in writing. Members are requested to make their written request via email to the data protection officer.

If VATSSA staff receive anything that might reasonably be construed to be a request to restrict processing, they have a responsibility to pass this to the data protection officer without delay.

6.5.3 Provision for verifying identity

Where the person managing the access procedure does not know the individual personally, there should be provision for checking their identity before handing over any information.

6.5.4 Fee Provisions

VATSSA will not charge any fee for providing data for requests under the right to restrict processing.

6.5.5 Exemptions

To ensure there is no retaliation or harassment against VATSSA staff, and to protect the privacy of staff members, names of staff may be redacted.

6.6 Right to Object to Processing

6.6.1 Responsibility

Requests for personal data under the right to object to processing are the responsibility of the division director and their team. Such requests are required to be complied with within one month of the request being received. If circumstances prevent this from occurring, an extension of a further two months may be instituted by the data protection officer, provided that the member making the request is informed of this fact before the expiration of the original one-month deadline.

6.6.2 Procedure for making a request

Right to object to processing requests must be in writing. Members are requested to make their written request via email to the data protection officer.

If VATSSA staff receive anything that might reasonably be construed to be a request to object to processing, they have a responsibility to pass this to the data protection officer without delay.

6.6.3 Provision for verifying identity

Where the person managing the access procedure does not know the individual personally, there should be provision for checking their identity before handing over any information.

6.6.4 Fee Provisions

VATSSA will not charge any fee for providing data for requests under the right to object to processing.

6.6.5 Exemptions

To ensure there is no retaliation or harassment against VATSSA staff, and to protect the privacy of staff members, names of staff may be redacted.

6.7 Right to Data Portability

Members can obtain and reuse their personal data for whatever purpose. As such, VATSSA shall provide their data in a structured, usable, machine-readable format.

6.8 Rights to Automated Decision Making and Profiling

VATSSA does not knowingly process data through the use of artificial intelligence systems.

VATSSA does not knowingly collect data that may be reasonably construed to form a profile.

If it is believed that VATSSA has inadvertently collected profiles or processed personal data using artificial intelligence systems, the data protection officer should be contacted so that appropriate action can be taken, including the review and, where necessary, the erasure of data.

7. Roles and Responsibilities

7.1 Data Protection Officer

VATSSA1 is the appointed data protection officer for VATSSA.

The data protection officer is responsible for overseeing VATSSA's compliance with applicable data protection legislation, including EU GDPR and VATSIM's Data Protection and Handling Policy, and ensuring that VATSSA adheres to its obligations.

The data protection officer is the primary point of contact for all matters relating to data protection and handling within VATSSA. This includes but is not limited to:

- Enquiries regarding personal data processing
- Reporting of suspected data breaches
- Clarification of data protection obligations under this policy

The data protection officer may escalate matters to VATSIM's Membership Department when deemed necessary.

7.2 General Responsibilities

Each member and visiting member of VATSSA is required to ensure that personal data is not retained for longer than is necessary for the purpose for which it was collected. Personal data must not be stored beyond its required retention period, including on personal devices, email systems or in physical form, unless explicitly authorised for legitimate operational purposes in accordance with this policy.

It is the responsibility of VATSSA1 to determine which categories of personal data it is necessary for VATSSA to process and their retention period. This shall be available to the Tech Department and Membership Department upon request. The Tech Department shall determine the requirements for data administration and data maintenance pertaining to the relevant software. The Membership Department shall assist the data protection officer with data requests, including:

- The right of access
- The right of rectification
- The right to object to processing
- The right to restrict processing
- The right of erasure

8. Security

VATSSA employs access monitoring systems to ensure that access is not being abused and can be tracked back to a specific individual.

VATSSA employs standard SSL encryption to safeguard data. VATSSA also implements additional change-audit scripts and monitors to provide visibility into server and network activity.

Passwords are not stored by VATSSA. These are held by VATSIM and are not made available to VATSSA through the sign-in process.

In order to ensure continuity, VATSSA retains data backups of relevant systems to ensure a speedy recovery of impacted systems while maintaining data integrity and security.

The main specific risks to the security of data are:

- Phishing attacks to gain network access or CERT access
- Access by means of trojan or keylogging programmes on members' systems
- Access by upset staff members who have been granted access is also a risk.

Mitigation of the first two risks is by encouraging members who have a higher level of access to ensure they adhere to good security practices on their personal systems. The last risk is mitigated by access logging and reverting changes made by those who misuse access.

9. Data Retention and Storage

9.1 Storage

Data is stored in standard databases. Access is granted by the VATSSA Division Director.

Data may be transferred to other organisations within the VATSIM network to provide services to enhance and extend the simulated aviation environment or as required by law through a court order.

9.2 Data Retention

VATSSA data is retained indefinitely unless removal is requested from the data protection officer, as outlined in this policy.

10. Types of Data

VATSSA collects a range of personal data on members, both at the time of joining and while a member is connected to the VATSIM network for the purpose of ensuring the efficient functioning of the network. This data includes:

- The member's full name,
- VATSIM CID,
- VATSIM registered email address,
- Member's region, division and subdivision,
- The simulated Air Traffic Control and/or Pilot Rating they have obtained via training with the VATSIM network

This information is stored in a secure database. Signing is made through the VATSIM SSO, and so the VATSIM Data Protection Handling Policy also applies.

10.1 Third Party Data

VATSSA may collect data from VATSIM. Sign in is made through the VATSIM SSO, therefore VATSSA does not store passwords.

11. Breaches

Where a breach of data protection occurs, it is important that the data protection officer takes immediate steps to reduce the impact on those whose data is affected. The data protection officer must also report breaches to VATSSA1, who will inform the VATSIM Membership Department via a support ticket within 72 hours of becoming aware of the breach.

VATSSA1 may request that a data protection breach report is compiled. The breach report includes but is not limited to:

- Provide details of the incident;
- How it occurred;
- Steps taken to reduce the impact;
- Steps taken to ensure that the same breach does not occur again;
- Any issues which should be shared with the VATSSA Staff team to avoid similar incidents;
- Numbers of people affected and the type of information involved.

VATSSA1 is responsible for reporting the breach to the VATSIM Membership Department and will usually provide a copy of the breach report.

If it is not possible to gather all the required information regarding a breach within the required 72 hours, VATSSA1 will contact the VATSIM Membership Department to provide notification of the breach and inform them that further information is being gathered.

Staff with concerns around potential breaches of data protection should contact the data protection officer for advice.

12. Contact Details

Contact	Contact Details
VATSSA1	vatssa1@vatssa.com
Data Protection Officer	dpo@vatssa.com
VATSSA Membership Department	membership@vatssa.com
VATSSA Tech Department	tech@vatssa.com

13. Enforcement

13.1 Disciplinary Action

VATSSA has a zero-tolerance policy towards the inappropriate use of data and failure to comply with this policy will result in sanctions being imposed and referral to the VATSIM Membership Department. Sanctions are at the discretion of VATSSA1.

VATSSA reserves the right to restrict or revoke access to divisional services and infrastructure, including training services and communication platforms, in accordance with this policy and other applicable divisional procedures.

14. Authority

- This policy is enforced by the VATSSA data protection officer and authorised by the Division Director.
- Decisions made under this policy are final unless otherwise stated by VATSSA procedures.

14. Review and Amendments

- This policy is subject to biannual review to ensure continued relevance and effectiveness, or when otherwise requested by the Division Director.
- Amendments to this policy may be made by the VATSSA Data Protection Officer as required.
- Members will be expected to comply with the most current published version of this policy, published at <https://vatssa.com>.